nation. Interacting with the individuals we encountered during our strolls across different states got seamlessly woven into the fabric of our experience. Listening to their stories, sharing laughter-laden moments and delving into the intricacies of their lives added a rich layer of depth to our shared journey. Each encounter was akin to turning a new page in a captivating novel, revealing the varied hues and textures of our country, and bringing us closer together in the process.

It was a curious blend of amusement and revelation when many individuals would mistakenly perceive me as Chinese or Japanese. Initially, the amusement arose from the innocent confusion, but beneath the surface, it carried a profound learning. This misconception, I realized, sprang from the limited portrayal of the North-east in mainstream media. In response, I undertook the task of bridging this gap and offering a deeper understanding. Instead of taking offence, I chose to respond with a warm and friendly smile. Engaging them in conversations in Hindi, I sought to provide a glimpse into the vibrant and culturally diverse tapestry of the Northeast. Each interaction became an opportunity not just to dispel stereotypes, but also to share the intrinsic beauty and richness of our region with my fellow Indians. It became a chance to nurture unity and cultivate an appreciation for the varied heritage that our nation possesses, fostering a deeper sense of connection and pride in our shared identity.

Navigating my way through the journey with a sprained ankle demanded not just physical endurance, but a reservoir of inner strength and tenacity. Despite the persistent ache, the sheer delight I derived from witnessing the genuine smiles on people’s faces and feeling their infectious enthusiasm as they greeted us, especially upon spotting the Congress flag, was immensely fulfilling. These encounters became a poignant reminder that our Yatra was indeed leaving an indelible mark on people, a reminder that our efforts, despite the trials we endured, were meaningful. In the face of adversity, these moments of connection stood tall as a testament to the enduring impact of our shared journey, highlighting the strength of the human spirit and the power of shared endeavours.